

THERE WAS A PRESIDENT



A NOVEL OF THE REPUBLIC OF VALDORIA



By

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*"The worst thing a people can do
is hand their throat to a man
and then wait for him to decide
whether to squeeze."*

AUTHOR'S NOTE

This is a work of pure fiction. The Republic of Valdoria, its leaders, its cities, its institutions, its geography, and all persons named within are entirely invented. Any resemblance to any real nation, government, individual — living or dead — is coincidental and wholly unintended.

All organizations, international bodies, advocacy groups, statistical figures, and media outlets referenced in this novel are likewise fictional. No real institution is depicted, quoted, or implied. The events described draw on no specific real-world reports, documented history, or identified persons.

This novel is dedicated to those who suffer in silence — in every nation, in every era. These are imagined people in an imagined country. That their circumstances may feel familiar is a testament to the human condition, not a portrait of any specific reality.

— M.M.Z.

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PART I

The Day the Subsidy Died



*They told us the pain would be brief.
They did not say brief by whose calendar.*

OVERHEARD AT A BUS STATION IN VALDORIA CITY, YEAR ONE

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CHAPTER I

The Man Who Spoke One Word

He arrived at the podium in a white ceremonial robe so voluminous it seemed to have its own weather system — its own atmosphere — like a small republic of fabric wrapped around a man who had spent thirty years learning how to wear power before he actually had it. The cameras loved him. The crowds had been arranged to love him too: bused in from sympathetic neighborhoods, given shirts, given food, given the particular kind of hope that is really just the temporary suspension of memory.

His name, in the official records of the Republic of Valdoria, was Cornelian Adara Makenda. But in the newspapers, in the streets, in the bars where men nursed warm beer and argued about futures they could no longer afford to imagine, he was simply The Man Who Won. Not the Man Who Was Chosen. Not the Man the Country Wanted. The Man Who Won. The distinction mattered enormously to everyone except him.

The election had been the kind that produced winners but no victory. Forty percent of the votes, in a nation where the other sixty percent had splintered into protest and despair. Ballot boxes that appeared in the wrong places. Results that arrived before the counting. Regional governors who delivered their provinces like parcels, their loyalty purchased in the back rooms of hotels where the chandeliers cost more than a village school.

A tribunal deliberated for eleven months and ultimately decided, in the language of legal poetry, that while the irregularities were numerous, they were insufficiently irregular to disturb the already-disturbed outcome.

And so Cornelian Makenda stood at the podium on that brilliant morning, in the capital city of Valdoria, surrounded by foreign dignitaries who had flown in to offer congratulations with one hand and loan conditions with the other. The crowd cheered. The cameras rolled. Schoolchildren waved small flags made in a country three thousand miles away.

He cleared his throat. He said one word.

One word that landed on the Republic of Valdoria like a stone dropped from a great height into still water. One word that rippled outward into every market, every kitchen, every filling station, every school bus, every hospital corridor in the country. One word

that the poor heard first, always, because the poor are always positioned closest to consequences.

"The subsidy is gone." — Cornelian Makenda, inaugural address, Year One

He smiled. The cameras captured the smile and sent it around the world.

What the cameras could not capture — or chose not to — was what happened simultaneously in the northern neighborhoods of Valdoria City, where a woman named Bisi was filling her kerosene lamp and calculating, with the mathematics of the very poor, how many meals that fuel would cost her this week versus last week.

Within seventy-two hours of the speech, petrol prices had tripled. Within six months, they had increased by five hundred percent. The valdor, which had traded at four hundred and sixty to one foreign dollar when Makenda took office, would reach one thousand, then fifteen hundred, then seventeen hundred. Inflation climbed to thirty-two percent. Then higher. Food inflation alone cracked twenty-seven percent within weeks.

Seven hundred and sixty-seven manufacturing companies would close by the end of the first year. Three hundred and thirty-five more would enter distress. Factories emptied. Workers went home and did not come back. The jobs did not move to other factories; they simply ceased to exist, evaporating like water on the hot concrete of a Valdorian afternoon.

The World Development Bank, which had championed the subsidy removal as a reform, quietly revised its projections. By the end of the second year of Makenda's administration, it estimated that close to half of all Valdorians would be living below the international poverty line.

Half.

Nearly half of ninety million people.

Cornelian Makenda's smile had been captured in four hundred photographs that day. The hunger did not photograph as well.



He was sixty-one, or seventy-one, depending on which document you consulted. He had been governor of Valdoria City Province for eight years, during which the city had become simultaneously richer and poorer — gleaming towers rising while underneath them the infrastructure rotted, the water pipes cracked, the traffic calcified into permanent gridlock because the roads had not been built for the density of dreams that kept arriving from the hinterlands.

He had survived. That was the primary qualification for leadership in Valdoria. Not brilliance. Not vision. Survival. The ability to endure the political ecosystem without being consumed by it, which generally meant becoming part of it — learning its languages, its systems of favour and debt, its intricate rituals of loyalty and betrayal.

He had a country of ninety million people who had, in various ways, consented or been unable to prevent his arrival at the top. He had one word that had already begun to change everything.



CHAPTER II

What the Morning After Looks Like

Bisi sold tomatoes.

This is not a metaphor. She genuinely sold tomatoes, and peppers, and occasionally dried melon seeds, from a stall in the Oshandi section of Valdoria City that her mother had established thirty years earlier and left to her when her mother's knees finally refused to carry her anymore. The stall was number forty-seven in Row C of Oshandi Market, approximately two meters wide and one and a half deep, covered by a blue tarpaulin that had once been a different color.

She had two children. A boy of nine named Emeka, who attended the government primary school where the roof leaked and the textbooks were from a curriculum revised without the books being replaced. And a girl of six named Ada, who was not yet in school because the registration fee had been raised and Bisi was determining whether to pay it this month or next month or some month that kept receding.

She did not follow politics closely. She voted — she had always voted, her mother had told her that voting was the minimum dignity a citizen could insist upon — but she did not follow the tribunal proceedings or the subsidy debates. These were things that happened in a language she recognized as Valdorian but that did not feel addressed to her.

On the morning after the inauguration, she went to the fuel station. The queue stretched past the gate, past the compound wall, down the road, and around the corner. She counted the vehicles ahead of her and stopped counting at forty. She waited two hours. When she reached the pump, the attendant told her the price.

She said: "Say it again."

He said it again.

She stood for a moment in the white heat of the Valdorian morning with the calculation running in her head — cost of fuel, minus reduced purchasing power, divided by number of market days, multiplied by the school fee, the rent, the food, the children — and arrived at a number that did not balance.

She bought a smaller quantity than she needed. The tomatoes she bought that day cost thirty percent more than the day before because the truck that brought them from the

farming communities of the north had to pay more for fuel and had passed that cost forward, as costs always travel forward toward the people with the least ability to absorb them.

She raised her prices. Her customers bargained harder. She sold less.

That evening she cooked rice with very little stew and told Emeka there was no meat tonight. Emeka, who was nine and therefore old enough to understand that "soon" had started meaning something different from what it used to mean, did not argue. He ate his rice. He did his homework by the light of the kerosene lamp because she had not refilled the generator.

This is what the morning after looks like. Not collapse — collapse would at least be dramatic, would at least have the decency to announce itself. What the morning after looks like is small subtractions. A bulb unlit. A portion reduced. A fee deferred. A child who eats less than he should. A woman who wakes before dawn and does her mathematics in the dark and finds, each morning, that the numbers are slightly worse than yesterday's numbers.

Inflation reached 32%. Then 34%. Food inflation higher still.

Makenda held a press conference three weeks in. A journalist asked him directly: how do you respond to Valdorians who say the pain is unbearable? He leaned into the microphone and said, in a tone intended to sound empathetic: "I feel your pain."

The recording of those four words traveled through every messaging group in the Republic of Valdoria. "I feel your pain," said a man who had not stood in a fuel queue in thirty years. Who had not negotiated tomato prices. Who had not, by any visible evidence, modified his life in any measurable way in response to the crisis his policy had created.

People laughed. People wept. People shared it again with a caption that required no translation.



CHAPTER III

The Queue

In the final month of the first year of the Makenda administration, sixty-seven people died in a queue.

They were not, strictly speaking, standing in a fuel queue. They were standing in a food distribution queue — a relief effort organized by a local government office in the town of Koru, where a councilman had announced that bags of grain and root vegetables would be distributed to residents. Word spread the way word always spreads in communities where information travels faster than resources: through phones, through neighbors calling over fences, through children sent running to tell their mothers.

They began arriving before dawn. By six in the morning there were hundreds. By eight there were thousands. The field designated for the distribution was not designed for thousands. There were no crowd-management barriers. There were not enough bags of grain. The councilman's office had, in the tradition of Valdorian political generosity, announced a distribution for which the procurement had not been fully completed.

When the crush came, it came the way such things always come — suddenly, without warning, with the terrible physics of packed human bodies in a small space when something at the front goes wrong. The screaming started. People could not fall because there was nowhere to fall; they were held upright by the pressure of the crowd around them. Those who lost consciousness remained vertical for some time. Children were separated from their parents in the chaos. Women screamed names into a wall of noise.

Sixty-seven people died. Mostly women. Several children.

They had come for food. They had died for food. In a country that sat on top of one of the largest oil reserves on the continent. In a country that had earned hundreds of billions in resource revenue over the preceding decade. In a country whose president's inaugural robe had cost more than any of them would earn in a decade.

The councilman issued a statement expressing deep regret. The provincial governor issued a statement expressing deeper regret. The presidency issued a statement expressing the deepest regret, and announcing an investigation — which was the standard grammar of Valdorian official response to tragedy: statement, condolence, investigation announcement, silence.

The investigation, if it proceeded, produced no public report. The dead were buried.

In the capital, in the state house whose renovation had cost seventeen billion valdors — a number the president's office initially denied and eventually stopped denying — Cornelian Makenda reviewed macroeconomic reports and attended international summits and gave speeches about Valdoria's transformation.

The people who were not economists at distant investment banks continued to do their mathematics in the dark.

PART II

Blood on the High Grasslands



*They came in the night.
By morning we were counting who was not there.*

SURVIVOR, HARKAN DISTRICT, HIGH GRASSLANDS PROVINCE





CHAPTER IV

Before the Roosters Crowed

The High Grasslands are the green heart of Valdoria, a region of cool highlands and fertile farmland that has fed the republic's cities for as long as there have been cities to feed. The Beromi people have farmed this land for generations — yam, maize, cassava, sorghum — their calendar organized around planting seasons and harvest festivals, their villages arranged in patterns that reflect decades of knowing exactly which hillside catches the most rain and which valley holds the most soil.

They are, overwhelmingly, followers of the old highland faith — a tradition practiced with the concrete, daily aliveness of communities where faith is woven into work and family and identity. Their churches are not just buildings; they are the organizing structures of village life, the place where decisions are made and grief is processed and children learn that they are part of something larger than their immediate hunger.

The men who came before the roosters crowed on the night of the winter festival season were not from the High Grasslands. They spoke a different language. They wore no uniforms. They came with guns — automatic weapons that had traveled into the republic through the porous northern borders of a state that had lost effective control of its reaches years before anyone in the capital was willing to say so publicly.

They came on motorcycles and on foot, in organized groups that hit multiple villages simultaneously, which meant this was coordinated, which meant this was planned, which meant that somewhere in the weeks before that night someone had made a plan and that plan had not been detected, or had been detected and had not been interrupted.

Father Emmanuele Daladi, the local priest who would spend the following week walking among the ruins of twenty villages, told the aid workers who came afterward that what struck him first was the silence. Villages that should have been sleeping — that ordinary silence of rural night, dogs and insects and wind — were instead silent in a different way. The silence of absence.

Twenty villages. In one night.

They shot the men who ran. They shot the men who did not run. They set fire to the houses with people inside. They killed livestock and burned grain stores — destruction that was not incidental but deliberate, a way of ensuring that even those who survived

would struggle to remain.

By the following morning, approximately two hundred people were dead. Five hundred were injured. Thousands had fled into the surrounding bush, into the cold of the highland night, carrying children, carrying nothing, carrying only the animal imperative of continuing to live.

The governor of High Grasslands Province issued a statement. The security agencies issued a statement. The presidency issued a statement. The statements shared a common grammar: deep condemnation, full investigation, swift justice, the perpetrators will not go unpunished.

No one was prosecuted. Not for those villages. Not for the villages before, of which there had been many. Not for the villages after, of which there would be more.



CHAPTER V

What the Soldiers Did Not See

The military was present in the High Grasslands. This is important to establish. There were army installations in the region. There were joint security task forces. There were military commanders who received reports and filed reports and attended briefings about security conditions in the area. The security apparatus existed and was staffed and was funded.

What happened in twenty villages on that night happened in spite of this apparatus, or alongside it, or through some gap in it so large that a coordinated paramilitary force with automatic weapons could move through it unseen.

The highland farming communities — the Beromi and the Taroki and the Irigwi — had been raising alarms for years before that night. They had written letters. They had sent delegations to the provincial capital. They had sent delegations to the federal capital. They had said: there are men in the hills above our villages. They are armed. They have attacked communities this year. They will attack more. Please do something.

The something that was done was, in the assessment of those who survived what came after, insufficient.

An independent rights organization that tracked the killings systematically estimated that in the twelve months before the winter festival massacre alone, more than five hundred people had been killed across the region. In the twelve months following, the count would rise toward eight thousand. Eight thousand. In one year. In one country.

The attacks followed patterns that those who study such things recognized as tactical. They came at night, before dawn, when visibility was lowest and response time longest. They targeted multiple communities simultaneously to overwhelm security response. They destroyed food stores to ensure that even successful escape led to starvation. They kidnapped women and girls — dozens in a single attack, hundreds across a season.

They were not, officially, designated as terrorists. They were referred to in official Valdorian government communications as "armed bandits" — a category that implies opportunism and criminality rather than organized, ideologically motivated violence. The distinction mattered enormously in terms of how the security response was calibrated.

A global rights organization eventually called for an independent investigation. They noted that the authorities had failed to make a single arrest in connection with any of the major attacks. Not one prosecution. Not one conviction. The impunity was so complete it had a quality almost like announcement.

Nobody sent soldiers in time. The soldiers were already there, in installations twenty minutes from villages that were burning.



CHAPTER VI

A Festival Season in the Land of Ash

Mrs. Maryam Dazu was fifty-three years old and had never in her life missed a festival service. She had attended through illness, through flooding, through a year when the road to the meeting house had been washed out and she had walked three kilometers through mud to get there.

She did not attend the festival service in the year of the massacre because her place of worship had been burned to its foundation.

She sat instead in a displaced-persons shelter in a school building ten kilometers from her village, on a mat that someone from a relief organization had brought. The school building had no glass in most of its windows. The highland nights in the festival season are cold in the way that surprises people who think of Valdoria only as equatorial heat.

She had three grandchildren with her. Their parents — her son and his wife — were among the dead. The children did not know precisely what had happened to their parents. They knew the word "gone." They knew it with the totalizing certainty that children know such things, beneath language, in the body.

The youngest, a boy of four named Sami, had not spoken since the night they fled. He sat in Mrs. Maryam's lap and watched the other people in the school building with eyes that had seen something eyes his age should not contain.

In the shelter, which is what the school building had become, there were approximately four hundred people. They had been given some food by local congregations and some blankets by a relief organization that had mobilized faster than the government. The government relief arrived ten days later — partial, disorganized, insufficient.

A foreign observer organization had, over the preceding four years, documented more than sixteen thousand members of highland farming communities killed in Valdoria. The international diplomatic community weighed this against oil contracts and security cooperation agreements. The scale did not tip toward the dead.



CHAPTER VII

The Planting Moon, Again

Sister Ngozi Ihedu had been a nurse in the High Grasslands for twenty-two years. She had delivered babies in villages with no electricity, performed triage in conditions that would have appalled the hospitals she had trained in, made do with less for so long that less had become her professional baseline.

After the planting-moon attacks, she worked for fourteen hours without stopping.

She would not describe, later, what she saw, because she said it was not hers to describe — it belonged to the people it had happened to. What she would say was that the wounds were not random. The kind of wounds she treated were the wounds of coordinated attack, not of spontaneous violence. Someone had organized this.

She wanted to know who that person was. She wanted to know why that person was not in a courtroom. She wanted to know why she was treating wounds that official Valdorian policy seemed determined to pretend were not being made.

She received, eventually, a certificate of recognition from the provincial government for her humanitarian service. She framed it. She hung it in her office next to a photograph of the meeting house in her home village — the one she had attended since childhood, the one that had been burned twice and rebuilt twice, the one now attended by a congregation smaller than it had been because some of the congregation was in the ground.

The Valdorian government's counter-narrative was that the violence was primarily about land and livestock, farmer-herder competition, not ideology. The problem with this counter-narrative was that the communities being killed were the highland farming communities; the attackers were from groups that had adopted a foreign ideology; the timing of attacks frequently corresponded to harvest and festival seasons; and the meeting houses were burning alongside the people.

Mrs. Maryam's grandson Sami began speaking again, about three months after the massacre. The first word he said was the name of his father. He said it the way children say such names — with absolute certainty, as if the name could summon the person.

His father did not come. He said the name again.

PART III

The Man in the Cage



*They cannot silence a voice by putting it in a room.
They can only ensure that the room does the silence's work for them.*

LETTER SMUGGLED FROM THE BUREAU OF STATE INTELLIGENCE

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CHAPTER VIII

He Who Spoke of Separation

His name — his name in this story — is Obinna Okara-Nwosu. He was born in the southeastern region of Valdoria in the year the old republic collapsed and a separatist nation called Amara died officially — though not psychologically, not in the communities that had fought for it, lost, and were told to reintegrate into a republic that had spent years trying to suppress them.

He grew up with that lost cause as a story told in the pauses of adult conversation — in the thing his grandmother's hand did when certain words were said, in the particular silence of his father when anyone spoke of the old atrocities, in the way the southeast held its grief like something underground, pressurized, invisible from the surface but always there, always warm.

He left Valdoria in his twenties, acquired citizenship in a northern country, started a radio station that broadcast across the internet to the Valdorian diaspora and, increasingly, to communities in the southeast. He spoke, on his broadcasts, about self-determination. About the right of peoples to choose their political arrangements. He spoke of a nation called Amara — not the republic that had lost its war, but a future nation that existed as argument and aspiration.

He was provocative. He was loud. He said things that his listeners found thrilling and that the federal government of Valdoria found threatening. He called the northern political elite the enemies of eastern progress. He said the southeast was being treated as a colony within a republic that called itself a democracy. He called for a referendum.

He also, in the view of his critics and of prosecutors who would eventually enumerate their objections: incited violence. Called for attacks on security personnel. Used his broadcasts to direct his followers toward armed confrontation.

He denied this. He said he advocated non-violence. He said the context was being stripped from his words. He said the charges were political, designed to silence a voice the government could not answer with argument.

The truth, as in most such cases, was somewhere in the contested space between the government's characterization and his own. His broadcasts were incendiary. Some of his followers had committed violence. Whether the connection between his words and their

actions constituted legal responsibility — this was precisely the question the courts were supposed to answer.

The courts did not answer it quickly. He had been in solitary confinement in the headquarters of the Bureau of State Intelligence for years. Not in a prison — in the headquarters of the intelligence service. He faced seven counts. Some were capital offenses, punishable by death.

He had not been convicted of anything. He had not been acquitted of anything. He sat in a room in the headquarters of the state's security apparatus and the trial moved at the speed of institutional avoidance — adjourned, reassigned, contested, adjourned again.



CHAPTER IX

The Courtroom That Never Began

The court was a real court. It had a real judge. The judge wore robes. There was a bailiff. There were proceedings recorded in official transcripts. The lawyers stood and argued and sat and argued again. This was, structurally, a legal process.

What it was not, in the assessment of Okara-Nwosu's legal team and of various international human rights organizations that monitored it, was a fair trial. Not because the judge was manifestly corrupt — she was not, or at least the evidence for this was contested — but because the fundamental preconditions for a fair trial were absent.

He was in solitary confinement in a security facility, not a prison with standard prisoner rights. His lawyers' access to him was restricted to conditions set by the BSI, which had a vested institutional interest in his continued detention. The defense argued the original charges had been brought under conditions that invalidated the court's jurisdiction.

The trial judge recused herself. The case was reassigned. Then she was reassigned back. Okara-Nwosu refused to appear before her again. The case stalled for six months. International observers raised questions about the constitutional right to a speedy trial.

His legal team filed for bail — again. The bail application was denied — again. They filed for his release on constitutional grounds. None of these applications moved quickly. The system had a particular genius for institutional slowness when the alternative to slowness was a judgment that would either convict a man the government needed convicted or acquit a man the government needed to keep quiet.

His supporters held weekly economic shutdowns in his name. Entire southeastern provinces would go quiet on those days: markets closed, roads empty, children not in school. The economic cost was enormous, borne by the communities themselves, a form of collective suffering undertaken as protest.

Okara-Nwosu wrote, from his confinement: "I will not succumb to any trial conducted by any judge or court whose jurisdiction does not pass constitutional muster. Not now, not ever."



CHAPTER X

Four Years of Silence

The silence of a solitary confinement cell is not the silence of peace.

It is the silence of removal — removal from the sounds that constitute a life: voices, traffic, birdsong, the sound of a market, of cooking, of children arguing about nothing, of rain on a corrugated iron roof. When these sounds are taken away systematically, the human brain, which is designed for social input, begins to produce its own — fills the silence with its own noise, which is not always pleasant.

His lawyers reported that he was managing. That he maintained his dignity. That he continued to write, when he was permitted to write. That he continued to insist on his position: that his confinement was illegal, that his trial was compromised, that the republic he was being asked to demonstrate loyalty to had not demonstrated loyalty to him or to the people he came from.

The government of Cornelian Makenda inherited this situation from his predecessor but made no visible effort to resolve it through the political means available to an executive — negotiation, amnesty discussion, political dialogue with southeastern leaders. The institutional preference was for the courts to handle it, which meant for it to continue not being handled.

By the end of the fourth year, the court finally delivered its judgment. He was convicted. He was sentenced to life in prison. His supporters said the trial had been a performance of justice rather than justice itself. The government said the rule of law had been upheld.

Both statements were true in the way that contradictory statements can share the same landscape. The rule of law had been technically observed. The fundamental fairness of the process was permanently in question. A man would spend the rest of his life in prison for crimes that his community believed he had not committed.

This is how grievances become generational. This is the sediment that history deposits.

PART IV

The Shepherd and His Flock



*The true shepherd does not ask whether speaking is convenient.
He asks only: are the wolves among my sheep?*

OLD VALDORIAN PROVERB





CHAPTER XI

The Prophet of the Gleaming Cathedral

His name — his name in this story — is Prophet Josias Adekora Bolarindi. He is eighty-three years old. He has been preaching for fifty-nine of those years. He leads the Throne of Eternal Radiance and Global Covenant Ministry, headquartered on a campus outside Valdoria City that covers forty-two hectares and includes a six-thousand-seat auditorium, a conference center, a hotel, a university, a medical center, and a sports complex.

The ministry's membership is estimated at ten million people across the republic. Its broadcast operations reach a hundred and sixty-eight countries. Its annual convention draws visitors from every continent — the faithful who sleep on mats in the church grounds for three days, who give their savings for transport across the republic to sit in the presence of a man who has told them that divine favour is available to anyone who believes strongly enough and plants the right seeds of faith — by which he means financial contributions to the ministry.

Prophet Bolarindi has built hospitals. He has built schools. He has trained pastors who serve in communities that no government program has reached. He has, genuinely, done good. This must be said. The balance sheet of his life is not simple.

He is also, by any reasonable assessment, one of the wealthiest men in Valdoria. The prosperity theology that undergirds his ministry — the idea that faith produces material blessing, that wealth is divine favour made visible, that giving to the ministry is an investment that heaven will return multiplied — has made him rich in ways that require careful navigation.

He owns properties. He travels in a private jet. He receives visitors of the kind who do not generally wait in queues — heads of state, ministers, governors, the powerful of Valdoria who understand that a man with ten million followers is a person whose blessing is worth seeking. Cornelian Makenda had visited the campus before the election. He had sat in the front row of the six-thousand-seat auditorium and received prayer, and the cameras had been there, and the image had been useful.

He was, in short, the most powerful religious leader in the Republic of Valdoria.



CHAPTER XII

The Shepherd's Silence Has a Private Jet

When the winter festival massacre happened, the people of the High Grasslands waited for their shepherd to speak.

Not in the way one waits for a politician — without much expectation, with the practiced disappointment of long experience. They waited the way a flock waits for a shepherd: with genuine, trusting expectation, because the shepherd had told them for fifty-nine years that he stood between them and darkness.

Prophet Bolarindi did not issue a statement condemning the winter festival massacre within the first week. His office eventually released a message asking for prayers for the victims and for peace in the region. It was the statement of a man's communications department, not of a prophet. It said nothing specific. It named no perpetrators. It made no demands on the government. It offered prayer where the moment required confrontation.

This is not a simple accusation. A spiritual leader in a politically polarized country operates within constraints that are not always visible. If he speaks too specifically, he becomes a political actor and loses his ability to operate as a spiritual one. These are real considerations.

But there is a point at which these considerations become their own kind of moral choice. When eight thousand people who share your faith are killed in a single year. When children are murdered at the festival season. When women are kidnapped and no official is arrested and no trial is held. When the government of a man who sat in your front row and received your blessing watches all of this and issues statements and does nothing — at this point, pastoral neutrality is not spiritual wisdom. It is silence purchased by proximity to power.

His congregation in the High Grasslands understood this geometry. They lived in it. They attended his broadcasts in the displaced-persons shelters and the ruined villages, and they heard about faith and blessing and the prosperity that the divine intended for his children, and they looked at the ruins of their villages and the graves of their neighbors and they performed a kind of spiritual mathematics that did not entirely add up.

Father Emmanuele, the local priest who had walked among the ruins, did not have a private jet. When a journalist asked him what he thought of the major religious leaders' response to the massacres, he said, very carefully: "Sheep know the voice of their shepherd. They also know when the shepherd is not in the field."



CHAPTER XIII

When the Shepherd Looked Away

There are several stories about why powerful men stay silent in the face of catastrophe. The most flattering is strategy – the idea that silence preserves influence that can be used later. The evidence for this theory's success is generally thin.

The least flattering story is comfort. Power is comfortable. Access is comfortable. The relationship with the powerful is comfortable, and confronting power risks the comfort. This is not a story that any powerful man tells about himself, but it is the story that the powerless read in the behaviour of those who could speak and choose not to.

The congregations of the High Grasslands had a third interpretation, which they offered privately, in the language of faith: a prophet who cannot speak when his people are being slaughtered is a prophet whose voice has been leased rather than given.

This is the most devastating theological judgment a congregation can make about its shepherd. It means not that he is bad but that he has become something other than what he claimed to be. That the title and the ministry and the auditorium and the private jet have become ends in themselves.

There was a holy morning, several months after the festival massacre, when Prophet Bolarindi preached a sermon on the theme of breakthrough. He spoke of divine power to break through every obstacle. He spoke of the ministry's expansion to three new countries. He invited the congregation to give generously.

The names of the dead were not read. The villages that had burned were not named. The question of why the government was not arresting anyone was not raised.

This is not an accusation of evil. It is a documentation of absence. The absence of the names. The absence of the demand. The absence of the shepherd in the field.

History is written partly in what was said and partly in what was not. The silence of the powerful in the face of the suffering of the powerless is a text as legible as any sermon. They do not forget this lesson. They pass it to their children.

PART V

The Republic of Uniforms



*In Valdoria, there are two kinds of law:
the law of the uniform and the law of the wealthy.
For the rest of us, there is only hope.*

VALDORIAN PROVERB





CHAPTER XIV

What the Special Enforcement Unit Did

The Special Enforcement and Interdiction Unit — SEIU — was formed to combat violent crime. It was disbanded, officially, after millions of Valdorians took to the streets in protest. It was disbanded in the sense that its name was retired and a new name was assigned to essentially the same personnel operating in essentially the same ways, which in institutional terms is not disbanding but rebranding.

The protests that led to the disbanding were the largest youth uprising in Valdoria's post-colonial history. Young people organized through social media, occupied roundabouts and expressways in every major city, and demanded, in the plainest possible language, that a unit of the security forces that had spent years terrorizing them be shut down.

The unit's practices, documented by a global rights organization in a special report, included: illegal detention, physical abuse of detainees, mock executions, extortion of anyone who could be identified as having money — young men who owned laptops, who dressed in ways that read as successful. In the particular logic of SEIU, visible evidence of prosperity was probable cause for investigation.

The protest was peaceful. The response was not.

At a gathering point on the edge of Valdoria City's most affluent district, security forces opened fire on peaceful protesters. The precise sequence of events was later disputed with the thoroughness that official institutions devote to the disputes of things they did and do not wish to be accountable for. Investigations were announced. Years later, the investigations had produced no prosecutions.

The unit operated by different initials now. Its officers were, in many cases, the same officers in different shirts. Citizens reported that the tactics continued.

A young man named Tobechukwu Osi-Mensah, a twenty-four-year-old graphic designer, was stopped at a checkpoint one afternoon. He was asked to explain his laptop. He explained it. He was asked to explain the foreign-currency payment apps on his phone. The officers were not interested in the documents. They were interested in the amount that would make the interest go away. He paid. He did not file a complaint. He knew what complaints became.



CHAPTER XV

The Bureau of Recovered Assets

The Bureau of Financial Integrity and Asset Recovery was established to fight corruption. This sentence needs no commentary on its irony; the irony is already fully present in the gap between the mandate and the practice.

The BFIAR had, over its existence, recovered significant sums from individuals convicted of financial crimes. It had prosecuted governors. It had prosecuted civil servants who had treated the public treasury as a personal account. It had done genuine anti-corruption work that had, in some cases, resulted in actual accountability.

It had also, over its existence, developed the institutional habit of deploying its powers selectively — against the enemies of whoever was currently in power, while declining to investigate the friends of whoever was currently in power.

In one operation during the Makenda years, BFIAR operatives raided a residential estate at five in the morning, on the basis of intelligence that the estate harbored financial fraudsters. The raid netted dozens of arrests. The estate's residents were mostly university students.

Among those arrested was Agabi, a twenty-six-year-old student whose wife was expecting their first child. He was held for several days. The charges did not ultimately proceed. His wife lost the pregnancy during the period of his detention. She did not receive an apology.

Seventy-three percent of Valdorians, in a major polling survey conducted during the Makenda years, said that most or all security officers were corrupt. It was the assessment of a population that had extensive, daily experience of the institution being rated and had arrived at its conclusion empirically.

The young people of Valdoria had arrived at a particular form of exhaustion that is different from ordinary tiredness. It is the exhaustion of the repeatedly disappointed. Of the generation that was told by everyone that its future was important and then shown, repeatedly, that the importance was rhetorical.

Some of them left the country. Nurses left. Doctors left. Engineers left. Teachers left. The brain drain accelerated into something that looked, in the Makenda years, less like a

drain and more like a hemorrhage.



CHAPTER XVI

The Boys Who Chose the Shadow

Chidera was twenty-two when he made his choice. He had finished secondary school. He had a mother who sold fabric in the eastern commercial city. He had a father who had worked in a factory that was among the seven hundred and sixty-seven that closed in the first year of the Makenda administration. He had a younger brother who needed school fees, a younger sister who needed school fees, and a grandmother whose medication had quadrupled in price.

He had a phone. He had internet access, intermittent. He had intelligence — his teachers had noted it, his exam results had reflected it. He had the material of a life that, in different circumstances, might have gone somewhere clearly recognizable as good.

The shadow economy that young men in Valdoria call the underground — named for the hidden networks through which it operates — had existed for decades. The later generations of practitioners were technically sophisticated, psychologically trained, operationally organized.

Chidera knew men who did it. Some of them had built houses for their mothers. Some of them drove cars that they parked on streets where the gutters had not been repaired in a decade.

The moral mathematics of choosing the underground in Chidera's circumstances is not simple. He was not a monster. He was a young man in a system that had provided him with intelligence and no reliable path for that intelligence to travel, that had presented him with the choice between patient suffering and active transgression and had not, in any meaningful sense, provided a third option.

A society is responsible for the choices it makes available to its young. This is not a controversial proposition. It is, however, a proposition that governments find inconvenient, because it shifts responsibility from the individual who made the choice to the institutions that shaped the choice set.

Chidera was convicted and sentenced. His grandmother died while he was in prison, without the medication her body required. Nobody investigated that death.

PART VI

The Weight of a Nation



*They told us to be patient.
We have been patient for sixty years.
Patience has a shelf life.*

PROTEST SIGN, VALDORIA CITY, YEAR TWO





CHAPTER XVII

Mothers at the Relief Line

There is a particular sound that a relief distribution line makes in the early morning in a poor neighborhood in Valdoria. It is the sound of patience – not comfortable patience, not the patience of people who have other options and are choosing to wait, but the patience of people for whom this line is a necessity.

Amaka came to the line at five in the morning to be twenty-third instead of two hundred and twenty-third. She brought her youngest because she had no choice. She wore house slippers because her good shoes had been resoled twice and she saved them for occasions that required them.

She was forty years old. She had a university degree in accounting. She had worked for a shipping company until the company's operational costs made it unprofitable and it closed. She was good at her work. Her work was not sufficient to sustain a family of four in the Valdoria of the Makenda administration.

She stood in the line and did not speak of this to anyone because there was nothing useful to say and because the woman behind her had a similar story and the woman behind that woman had a similar story and the line stretched back through the morning heat, full of similar stories, full of women who had degrees and skills and capabilities that the economy they lived in could no longer absorb at prices that covered rent.

What she received at the end of the line: a five-kilogram bag of grain. A small measure of legumes. A bottle of cooking oil.

She thanked the distribution worker. She walked home carrying the bag and the child. She had already calculated, before she joined the line, how many days the bag would last her family at the portion sizes she would need to make it last.

The state house, nine kilometers from Amaka's house, had been renovated during the first year of the Makenda administration at a cost of seventeen billion valdors. The presidential spokesperson, when asked about the renovation, said that maintaining the dignity of the seat of government was a legitimate state expense. That audience was not Amaka.



CHAPTER XVIII

The Day the People Stood Up

In the second year of the Makenda administration, the people stood up.

They had stood up before — in the SEIU protests, when the blood at the gathering point had momentarily clarified what the relationship between the state and its young people actually was. But that had been specific, targeted, about a single unit. This was different. This was about everything.

The rallying phrase was #EndBadGovernance. It was not subtle. It did not require explanation. It was the political vocabulary of a people who had exhausted more polite formulations.

They occupied the major roundabouts and expressways. They stood in the heat with signs. They chanted. They recorded. They live-streamed. They were not all young — there were fifty-year-olds in the crowds, sixty-year-olds, people who had been alive for every administration since independence and had made their own cumulative accounting and arrived at their own verdict.

The government's response was, in some cities, proportionate. In others, it was what it had been before: water cannons, tear gas, officers who did not understand that shooting the people protesting against being shot is not a strategy that improves trust.

Makenda appeared on television. He looked tired. He spoke about the difficulty of the transition, the long-term nature of the reforms. He said he felt their pain.

The protests subsided. They always subside. The body gets tired. The job, where there is a job, threatens consequences for continued absence. The children need feeding. The mathematics of survival reasserts itself and pulls people back from the roundabout into the domestic arithmetic of their lives.

The people went home with the knowledge that they had stood up, which is different from the knowledge that the standing had worked.



CHAPTER XIX

The President Gives a Speech

Three years into his administration, Cornelian Adara Makenda gave a speech at the annual dinner of the Valdoria Investors' Forum. He wore a blue ceremonial robe. The room was full of men and women who had done well in Valdoria — who owned companies, who managed portfolios, who had arrived at this dinner rather than at the relief line.

He spoke about transformation. The word transformation does enormous work in Valdorian political speech — it is large enough to encompass any reality and flexible enough to be applied to any outcome.

He did not speak of Bisi, who still sold tomatoes but sold fewer of them to customers who bought less of everything. He did not speak of Mrs. Maryam's grandson Sami, who spoke now but whose parents were still in the ground. He did not speak of Okara-Nwosu, now serving a life sentence. He did not speak of Chidera, in prison. He did not speak of the sixty-seven people who died in the food distribution crush.

He did not speak of Amaka, who stood in the relief line at five in the morning in her house slippers.

He spoke of Valdoria's potential. He spoke of the digital economy, of the creative industries, of Valdorian music and fashion and film that were conquering international markets. These were genuine accomplishments of Valdorians despite the government rather than because of it.

He received applause. He smiled the smile that had been photographed four hundred times on the day he said one word. He shook hands and was driven back to the state house, past the neighborhoods where the electricity had been off for two days, past the checkpoint where the officer who had extorted Tobechukwu was still working his shift.

What was clear — what was not available for reasonable dispute — was the suffering. The suffering was not a narrative framing. The suffering was not a political position. The suffering was Bisi's calculation at the fuel station. It was Mrs. Maryam in the cold school building. It was Sami saying his father's name. It was Amaka in house slippers at five in the morning.

He gave his speech. He smiled. The republic went on.

EPILOGUE

There Will Be Another



There will be another president.

There always is. The republic produces them the way it produces everything — in abundance, unevenly distributed, with considerable ceremony surrounding the distribution and considerable silence about the conditions of production. There will be another inauguration, another ceremonial robe, another speech, another one word or two words or a whole sentence that changes everything in ways that will take years to fully account.

The question that this story has been circling — the question that the dead in the High Grasslands and the man in the cage and the woman in the relief line and the boy in prison all constitute an argument for — is whether the next president will be different. Whether the republic has accumulated enough of its own suffering to produce the kind of transformation that speeches promise but that actually requires something more uncomfortable: accountability.

Accountability meaning: the soldiers who stood in installations while twenty villages burned will answer for why they did not move. Accountability meaning: the officials who signed off on renditions and indefinite solitary confinement will be asked whether these actions comported with the laws they were sworn to uphold. Accountability meaning: the names of the dead will be read aloud in a public forum, and the reading will not be followed by a prayer for peace and an announcement of an investigation but by actual consequence.

Bisi is still at her stall. The prices are still too high, but she has found, in the way that humans find things when they have no alternative, small adjustments that make the mathematics work slightly better than they did at their worst. "Managing" is the Valdorian word for a form of survival that involves too much dignity to accept being called suffering, even when it is.

Mrs. Maryam is in a rebuilt house in a village that is being slowly reoccupied. Sami goes to school. He speaks now — more each month, the language returning to him like a field recovering after a long drought. He will carry what happened inside him for the rest of his life. He will also carry his grandmother's hands, which held him through the coldest nights.

The man in the cage has been sentenced. His supporters say this is not the end of the story. They may be right. History does not respect the finality of courts in the way that courts imagine they deserve to be respected.

Tobechukwu Osi-Mensah now works as a graphic designer abroad. He left on a work visa. He sends money home monthly. He does not know when he will return. He is not certain he will.

Amaka does bookkeeping for three small businesses and teaches accounting to secondary school students in the evenings. She has not stood in a relief line since. The economics are still precarious. She has made her peace with precarious.

The republic goes on. This is the thing about republics — they go on. They absorb suffering and failure and corruption and massacre and injustice and political catastrophe and they continue, in the way that large organisms continue, by redistributing the damage to the parts of the body least able to defend themselves.

There will be another president. He or she will stand at a podium and speak of transformation and potential and the new Valdoria that is arriving. The cameras will be there.

Whether anything changes depends not on the speech but on the accumulated weight of everyone who refused to absorb quietly. The woman who wrote a letter to her representative. The priest who walked among the ruins and documented what he saw. The journalist who published the contract details. The young people who sat at roundabouts in the heat and held their signs.

The dead depend on the living to carry what happened.

This book is an attempt to carry it.



*A people that does not know its history
is a people that does not know itself.
And a people that does not know itself
cannot govern itself.
It can only be governed.*

ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

This novel is a work of fiction. All persons, places, organizations, and events depicted herein are imaginary. No reference to any real individual, living or deceased, is intended or should be inferred. All statistics, quotes, and institutional references are invented.

The author acknowledges the tradition of political fiction that dares to imagine the world as it might be, and to interrogate the world as it is – through the safer distance of invented names, invented nations, and invented histories that carry within them universal questions about power, justice, and human dignity.

To those who read early drafts, who offered counsel on how a work of serious political fiction can carry moral weight without carrying legal risk: the author is grateful. Any remaining imperfections are the author's own.

— M.M.Z.

This is a work of fiction. The Republic of Valdoria and all characters, organizations, events, and places within are entirely invented. No real person, institution, nation, or event is depicted or implied. Any resemblance to actual persons living or dead, actual organizations, actual nations, or actual events is purely coincidental.